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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 9 — Attachments, Session 1: Governance & Finances

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 9, Session 1. Attachments are not afterthoughts — they are the evidence that proves your organization is capable of delivering on everything your narrative promises. Complete each section in order. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 9, Session 1. Each one maps to a specific attachment category.

Attachments Package	The collection of supporting documents included with a grant proposal. Together they answer the funder's unspoken question: is this organization real, well-run, and trustworthy with our money?
Board of Directors List	A roster of your organization's governing board. Must include each member's board position, professional occupation or title, and community affiliations. Signals governance quality, expertise, and community connectivity.
Board Position	The role a board member holds within the governance structure: Chair, Vice Chair, Treasurer, Secretary, or Member at Large. Required on every board list.
Community Affiliations	The organizations, institutions, and networks a board member is connected to outside your board. Signals breadth of community connection and external credibility.

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Anti-Discrimination Statement	A formal, board-adopted policy stating that the organization conducts all hiring, compensation, professional development, and service delivery without regard to any protected characteristic. Must be voted on at a board meeting and recorded in minutes.
Board Adoption	The formal process of a board voting to approve a policy at a recorded meeting. Required for the anti-discrimination statement to be valid. A policy that was never formally adopted is not a board policy.
Key Staff List	A roster of the staff members who will carry out the funded program. Includes name, title, credentials, relevant experience, and whether a bio or resume is attached. Vacant positions should be listed with hiring qualifications.
Fiscal Year-End Financial Statements	Official financial statements from the most recently completed fiscal year. Includes income statement (revenue and expenses) and balance sheet (assets, liabilities, net position). Audited statements carry the most funder credibility.
Audited Financial Statements	Financial statements reviewed and certified by an independent CPA. The highest standard of financial credibility for funders. Required by many mid- to large-size foundations.
Organizational Operating Budget	Your full budget for the current fiscal year — all revenue sources and all expenses across every program and administrative function. Gives funders context to assess whether your grant request is proportionate.
Program / Project Budget	An itemized budget for the specific program or project being funded by this grant. Every line item should be traceable to something described in the narrative. Alignment between budget and narrative is a sign of a well-planned proposal.
10% Benchmark	A widely used guideline: a single grant request should generally not exceed 10% of your total organizational budget, especially with new funders. Exceeding this creates dependency risk that funders notice.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated examples below. The right column explains what each element communicates to a funder. As you read, identify which elements your own attachments currently include and which ones need strengthening.

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Sample: Board List Entry, Staff List Entry, and Financial Proportionality

ATTACHMENT CONTENT	WHAT IT COMMUNICATES
[BOARD LIST — SAMPLE ENTRY] Patricia Okonkwo Board Chair <i>Chief Financial Officer, Riverside Community Health System</i> <i>Community Affiliations: Board of Directors, United Way of the Inland Region; Advisory Council, Riverside County Office of Education; Member, National Association of Healthcare Financial Management</i>	→ Board position named: Chair → Professional title signals financial expertise at governance level — a CFO overseeing your finances is reassuring → Three community affiliations show breadth of network → United Way + County Office of Education = direct connection to both funder networks and your target population
[KEY STAFF LIST — SAMPLE ENTRIES] Maria Delgado Program Director <i>MSW, 14 years in workforce development. Former program manager at [County Agency]. Fluent in English and Spanish. Has managed four federal grants totaling \$2.1M. Resume attached.</i> VACANT Career Coach (2 positions) <i>Will be hired using grant funds. Minimum qualifications: Bachelor's degree in social work, counseling, or related field; 2 years direct service experience with opportunity youth; bilingual English/Spanish preferred. Hiring to begin within 30 days of award notification.</i>	→ Credential (MSW) + years of experience + relevant context (county agency, bilingual) → Grant management history quantified: \$2.1M across four grants = proven track record → Vacancy listed transparently with hiring timeline — not hidden → Minimum qualifications for vacancies show the funder you know exactly what you need
[BUDGET PROPORTIONALITY — FINANCIAL CONTEXT] <i>Organization's total annual operating budget: \$680,000</i> <i>Grant request: \$58,000 (8.5% of total budget)</i> <i>The requested amount represents less than 10% of our total operating budget, with the remainder supported by three additional funders, government contracts, and earned revenue.</i>	→ 8.5% = below the 10% benchmark — signals the organization is not dependent on this funder → Explicitly names three other revenue channels = diversified funding base → Quantifying the percentage is optional but shows self-awareness and invites confidence

□ **Team:** As a group: review your organization's current board list. Does every entry have all three required elements? Which entries are incomplete? Assign someone to collect updated information from each board member before your next submission.

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Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what builds funder confidence. Answer the reflection question after each pair.

Comparison 1 — Board List Entry

☐ **Weak**

James Osei | Member James Osei | Member

☐ **Strong**

*James Osei | Board Treasurer Vice President of Finance, Meridian Technology Group
Community Affiliations: Treasurer, Downtown Business Improvement District; Advisory Board, County Small Business Development Center; Volunteer, SCORE (mentoring entrepreneurs)*

☐ **What does the strong board entry communicate that the weak one cannot? What would a funder infer about the organization from the weak entry?**

☐ **Team discussion:** *Pull up your current board list. How many entries are missing professional titles or community affiliations? Assign each board member a follow-up contact and a deadline to return their complete information.*

Comparison 2 — Key Staff Entry (Vacant Position)

☐ **Weak**

*TBD | Program Coordinator (to be hired)
Position not yet filled. Will hire using grant funds.*

☐ **Strong**

VACANT | Program Coordinator To be hired using grant funds within 45 days of award notification. Minimum qualifications: Bachelor's degree in human services or related field; 3 years direct service experience with court-involved youth; bilingual English/Spanish required; experience with case management software preferred. Salary range: \$52,000–\$58,000.

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- What does specifying hiring qualifications and a timeline communicate to a funder? Why does leaving a vacancy entry vague create doubt?

□ **Team discussion:** List any currently vacant positions in your program. For each one, draft the minimum qualifications and a realistic hiring timeline. This information belongs in both your staff list and your program timetable.

Comparison 3 — Financial Transparency

□ Weak

Our organization had a challenging year financially but we are committed to our mission and are working hard to improve our situation.

□ Strong

In FY2023, our organization experienced a \$42,000 operating deficit due to the loss of a major state contract that was not renewed. In response, we reduced administrative costs by 18%, secured two new foundation grants totaling \$95,000, and restructured our reserve policy. We ended FY2024 with a \$12,000 surplus and a three-month operating reserve for the first time in four years. Our audited financials for both years are included in the attachments.

- Why is transparent, specific disclosure of a financial challenge more credible to a funder than vague reassurance? What does the strong version demonstrate about the organization's leadership?

□ **Team discussion:** Has your organization experienced any financial challenges in the last two years? If yes, draft a two to three sentence honest disclosure with a corrective action statement. Hiding it is a greater risk than naming it.

Section 4 — Your Attachments Builder

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Complete each part below. By the end of this section you will have a clear picture of what is ready, what needs updating, and what is missing from your attachments package.

Part A — Board of Directors List

Complete the table below for every current board member. If any field is blank, it is an action item — not an option.

Board Member Name	Board Position	Professional Occupation / Title	Community Affiliations

☐ **Tip:** *If you need to contact board members for updated information, do it now — not the week before a deadline. Build a habit of updating this document at least once a year, ideally after each annual board meeting.*

☐ **Board composition reflection:** Does your board include at least one person with financial expertise (CPA, CFO, accountant)? Legal expertise? Someone with direct knowledge of the population you serve? Note any gaps and what type of board member would address them.

☐ **Team discussion:** *As a team, assess your board composition honestly. What expertise is missing? Does your board reflect the community you serve? Identifying gaps now is the first step to a stronger governance structure.*

Part B — Anti-Discrimination Statement

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☐ Does your organization have a formally adopted anti-discrimination statement? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Draft exists but has not been formally adopted

☐ If yes: When was it last updated? Does it reflect your current legal name, leadership, and all federally protected characteristics?

☐ If no or not formally adopted: What is your plan to adopt it? (Name the next board meeting date and who will bring the draft.)

★Example — Minimum required language:

The [Organization Name] does not discriminate in hiring, compensation, professional development, or service delivery on the basis of race, color, religion, national origin, sex, age, disability, sexual orientation, gender identity, veteran status, or any other characteristic protected by applicable federal, state, or local law. This policy applies to all employees, board members, and volunteers.

☐ **Tip:** The statement must be voted on at a formal board meeting and recorded in your board minutes. Attach a copy of the adopted policy — not a draft — to your proposal.

☐ **Team:** Assign someone to confirm the adoption status of your anti-discrimination policy before your next submission. If it needs to be placed on the board agenda, assign that action today with a specific meeting date.

Part C — Key Staff List

Complete the table below for every staff member with a meaningful role in the funded program. List vacant positions with hiring qualifications.

Name (or VACANT)	Title / Role	Credentials & Qualifications	Experience with This Population / Program Area	Bio / Resume Attached?

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☐ **Tip:** For leadership roles — Executive Director, Program Director, Clinical Supervisor — attach a one-page bio or condensed resume even if the funder guidelines do not require it. A funder who can see your program director's credentials will feel more confident in your capacity to deliver.

☐ **Team:** Review the completed staff table as a group. Does the team as a whole have the right combination of credentials, experience, and community knowledge to deliver this program? If there are gaps, address them in your hiring plan.

Part D — Financials

Complete the checklist below, then answer the reflection questions.

✓	Document	What It Shows the Funder	Current & Ready?	Notes / Action Needed
☐	Most Recent Fiscal Year-End Financial Statements Income statement (revenue & expenses) + balance sheet (assets, liabilities, net position)		☐ Yes ☐ No	
☐	Audit Type Audited (CPA-certified) / Reviewed / Compiled — circle which applies		☐ Yes ☐ No	
☐	Current Organizational Operating Budget All projected revenue sources + all planned expenses for the current fiscal year		☐ Yes ☐ No	
☐	Program or Project Budget Itemized budget for the specific program this grant funds (if project grant)		☐ Yes ☐ No	
☐	Budget Narrative Brief explanation of each line item (required by some funders)		☐ Yes ☐ No	

☐ **Your total organizational operating budget for the current fiscal year: \$**_____

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☐ The dollar amount of this grant request: \$_____

☐ What percentage of your total budget does this grant request represent? (Divide request by total budget.) _____% Is this at or below 10%?

☐ If your organization has experienced any financial challenges in the past two fiscal years, draft a brief, honest disclosure here (2–3 sentences). Include what happened, what you did about it, and where you stand now.

☐ **Tip:** Your program or project budget must align with your narrative. For every line item in the budget, there should be something in the proposal that explains it. A funder who finds a budget line they cannot trace to the program description will start asking questions.

☐ **Team:** Review your most recent audited financial statements as a group. Is there anything a funder might find unexpected? Discuss how to address it proactively in your narrative rather than leaving it unexplained in the financials.

Section 5 — Module 9 Session 1 Self-Audit Checklist

Check every box you can honestly say is true for your current attachments package. Unchecked boxes are action items — not options.

A — Board of Directors List

- ☐ Every board member entry includes their board position, professional occupation or title, and community affiliations.
- ☐ No entries are blank or list only a name and the word “Member.”
- ☐ The board list is current — it reflects actual current members, not people who have cycled off.

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- ☐ My board includes someone with financial expertise, legal expertise, or direct knowledge of the population served.
- ☐ My board's composition, background, and community connections are reflected in the board list.

B — Anti-Discrimination Statement

- ☐ My organization has a formally board-adopted anti-discrimination statement.
- ☐ The adoption was voted on at a formal board meeting and recorded in the minutes.
- ☐ The statement covers all federally protected characteristics and explicitly applies to employees, board members, and volunteers.
- ☐ The statement is current — it reflects the organization's current legal name and leadership.

C — Key Staff List

- ☐ Every staff member with a meaningful role in the program is listed with name, title, credentials, and relevant experience.
- ☐ Vacant positions are listed by title with minimum hiring qualifications and a realistic timeline.
- ☐ Leadership bios or condensed resumes are attached for key roles.
- ☐ The staff list as a whole demonstrates the right combination of credentials, experience, and community knowledge to deliver this program.

D — Financials

- ☐ My most recent fiscal year-end financial statements (audited or reviewed) are included: income statement + balance sheet.
- ☐ My current full organizational operating budget is included with all revenue sources and all expenses.
- ☐ A program- or project-specific itemized budget is included if this is a project grant.
- ☐ My grant request does not exceed 10% of my total organizational budget (or I have addressed this proportionality issue in my narrative).
- ☐ Every budget line item is traceable to something described in my narrative.
- ☐ If my organization has experienced financial challenges, I have addressed them transparently in my narrative with a corrective action statement.

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My action items before Session 2 / my next submission:

☐ **Team:** Assign each action item a team member and a due date. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.

*“A complete, current, professionally assembled attachments package
builds confidence before the funder has read a single paragraph.*

*A disorganized, outdated, or incomplete package
creates doubt — even when the narrative is strong.”*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 9